

STAGE ONE • SELF-AWARENESS & CAREER CLARITY

FIRSTS

GROUP FACILITATION TOOLKIT

Icebreakers, group-adapted exercises, and discussion prompts for live sessions

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

BY AYOMIDE AYENI

FIRSTS • Group Facilitation Toolkit

Stage One • Self-Awareness & Career Clarity

HOW TO USE THIS TOOLKIT

This toolkit is the live, in-room layer on top of the Facilitator Guide and Session Plan. Where those two documents tell you what to say and when, this one gives you what to actually run: a session-opening icebreaker, group-adapted versions of the FIRSTS that benefit most from live interaction, and discussion prompts to seed conversation beyond the individual worksheets.

Not every FIRST needs a group adaptation — some genuinely work best as quiet, individual reflection, and turning those into group activities would cheapen them. This toolkit only adapts the seven FIRSTS across Stage One where a live, social version adds genuine value beyond what solo worksheet time already provides.

Use the icebreaker at the start of its session, weave the group adaptations in wherever the Session Plan schedules that FIRST, and pull from the discussion prompts whenever a session has room to breathe or a share-out needs a nudge beyond “any volunteers?”

SECTION 1

Icebreakers

One opener per session, tied directly to that session's actual content — not generic filler. Each one does real cognitive warm-up work for the FIRSTS that follow.

SESSION 1

Two Truths and a Value

TIME: 10 min

1. Each person writes down two things they genuinely value (e.g., “I’d rather be broke and honest than rich and compromised”) and one thing that sounds like a value but is actually just a preference dressed up (e.g., “I value having a corner office”).
2. In pairs or small groups of three, each person shares all three without saying which is which.
3. The group guesses which one is the fake value. Facilitator debriefs: what made the fake one detectable? (Usually it's tied to status or convenience rather than principle.)

WHY THIS WORKS

This gets people laughing while doing the exact cognitive work FIRST 01 requires — distinguishing genuine values from dressed-up preferences — before the more serious individual work begins.

SESSION 2

Career Rumor Mill

TIME: 8 min

1. Ask the group: “What’s one thing you’ve heard about your target industry that you’re not sure is actually true?” (e.g., “I heard consulting is all 80-hour weeks,” “I heard startups don’t do performance reviews.”)
2. Go around quickly, one rumor per person, no elaboration needed.
3. Facilitator doesn’t fact-check yet — just collects them on a whiteboard or shared doc. Reference the list later during FIRST 08 (Industry Insight) as things worth verifying against real research.

WHY THIS WORKS

Surfaces exactly the kind of stereotype-based assumption FIRST 08’s Common Pitfalls warns against, and turns it into a natural, low-stakes group activity rather than a lecture point.

SESSION 3

Productivity Confessions

TIME: 8 min

1. Ask: “What’s one productivity hack you’ve tried that completely didn’t work for you, even though it works for everyone else?”
2. Quick round-robin, one sentence each. Encourage genuine, slightly embarrassing honesty (e.g., “I tried the 5am wake-up thing for two weeks and was useless all day”).

3. Facilitator notes the theme: what works is genuinely personal, which is exactly what this session's FIRSTS (14-18) are about to help each person figure out for themselves.

WHY THIS WORKS

Normalizes that generic advice doesn't work for everyone, which directly primes the session's core message: personality, work style, thinking style, and learning style are genuinely individual, not one-size-fits-all.

SECTION 2

Group-Adapted Exercises

Seven FIRSTS across this stage genuinely benefit from a live, social version beyond solo worksheet time. Run these in addition to, not instead of, the individual reflection — the group activity works best once participants already have their own answer to build from.

FIRST 01

Core Values Audit — Paired Interview

TIME: +10 min beyond solo work

1. After individual reflection, pair participants up.
2. Partner A interviews Partner B using just one question: “Tell me about a time you had to choose between two good options — what did you actually pick, and why?” Partner A listens for the value underneath the answer, without naming it yet.
3. Partner A then guesses: “It sounds like ___ might be one of your core values — does that land?” Partner B confirms or refines.
4. Swap roles.

FACILITATOR NOTE

This works because values are often easier for an outside listener to name from a real story than for the person to name abstractly on their own. It's a genuinely useful gut-check on the solo worksheet answers.

FIRST 04

Personal Brand Narrative — Practice Circle

TIME: +15 min beyond solo drafting

1. Groups of 3–4. Each person delivers their brand narrative out loud, from memory if possible (not read off the page).
2. After each delivery, the group gives exactly one piece of feedback each: one thing that landed clearly, one word or phrase that felt vague or generic.
3. Speaker revises one sentence on the spot based on the feedback, then moves to the next person.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Saying it out loud reveals awkward phrasing that looks fine on paper. Keep feedback to the two-question format above — open-ended “any thoughts?” feedback tends to be too vague to be useful here.

FIRST 06

Weakness Awareness — Opt-In Small Circle

TIME: +10 min beyond solo work

1. Explicitly frame this as fully optional before starting.

2. For those who opt in: groups of 3. Each person shares just their thirty-day action (not the weakness itself, if they'd rather keep that private) — e.g., “I’m going to practice cold-calling three people a week.”
3. Group members can offer one resource or contact if they genuinely have one relevant; otherwise, just a supportive acknowledgment.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Never require this share. The action-only framing (rather than naming the weakness itself) makes it lower-stakes while still creating real peer accountability.

FIRST 07

Passion Alignment — Cross-Pollination Groups

TIME: +15 min beyond solo mapping

1. Groups of 4, ideally with varied target industries.
2. Each person shares their top two passions from their mapping table (not the career links yet).
3. The rest of the group brainstorms career links they wouldn't have thought of themselves, for 90 seconds per person.
4. Original person adds any genuinely new ideas to their table.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Outside perspective often surfaces career paths the person hadn't considered simply because they're too close to their own passions to see them as marketable skills.

FIRST 09

Career Path — Research Jigsaw

TIME: Replaces solo LinkedIn scan; same total time

1. Groups of 3–4, each targeting a similar broad field.
2. Assign each person a different seniority level to research on LinkedIn (entry, mid, senior) rather than having everyone do all three alone.
3. Each person traces 3 real professionals at their assigned level and notes common entry points.
4. Group reconvenes and pools findings into one shared career-path map covering all three levels.

FACILITATOR NOTE

This produces a richer, faster result than everyone doing the full scan solo, and it's a natural way to build real peer connections around a shared target field.

FIRST 12

Career SWOT Analysis — Blind Spot Swap

TIME: +10 min beyond solo drafting

1. Pairs. Each person shares only their Strengths and Opportunities paragraphs (not Weaknesses/Threats) with their partner.

2. Partner listens, then offers one Weakness or Threat they'd genuinely add based on what they just heard — something the person may be blind to.
3. Each person decides whether to incorporate the outside perspective into their own analysis.

FACILITATOR NOTE

People are often more comfortable hearing a blind spot named by a peer than confronting it alone, and outside perspective genuinely catches things self-assessment alone misses.

FIRST 14

Personality Assessment — *Guess-the-Type*

TIME: +10 min beyond solo reflection

1. Before revealing results, small groups try to guess each other's four-letter type (or equivalent) based only on how people have behaved in the session so far.
2. Each person then reveals their actual result and shares whether the group's guess was close.
3. Quick discussion: what specifically gave it away, or what was surprising about being wrong?

FACILITATOR NOTE

This is genuinely fun and also reinforces the core lesson: personality shows up in observable behavior, not just self-report — useful groundwork for FIRST 22 (Professional Reputation Audit) much later in the program.

SECTION 3

Discussion Prompts

Open-ended questions to seed conversation beyond the individual worksheets — useful for share-out portions, when a session has extra time, or when a group's energy needs a genuine prompt rather than “any volunteers?”

SESSION 1

Foundations of Self

“What's a value you hold that would surprise people who only know you casually?”

“Has anyone ever taken a job or opportunity that looked great on paper but violated something they now recognize as a core value? What happened?”

“Where did your career vision come from — genuinely your own, or partly inherited from family or cultural expectation? How do you tell the difference?”

“What's a strength you have that you almost left off your list because it felt too obvious or ordinary to count?”

SESSION 2

Aligning with the Market

“What's a passion you have that you've assumed could never become a career? Is that actually true, or just untested?”

“What's the most surprising thing you learned researching your target industry today?”

“If salary were genuinely no object, would your target role change? What does that tell you about what you actually want?”

“Looking at your SWOT, which quadrant was hardest to write honestly, and why?”

SESSION 3

Working Style & Systems

“What's a work environment or team dynamic that's brought out your worst work, even though nothing was technically wrong with it?”

“Describe a decision you made quickly that turned out well, and one you rushed that you regret. What was actually different between them?”

“What's a subject or skill you were told you were ‘bad at’ that you now suspect was actually just taught in a format that didn't match how you learn?”

“What's one productivity system or habit you're willing to commit to trying for the next two weeks, starting today?”